

# EASTERN PROMISES

The prime minister unveiled a Rs 10,000-crore package for India's 'land of the rising sun'



km comes under Arunachal Pradesh. At present three army corps, or over three lakh troops, are deployed in the North-east, a majority of them for counter-insurgency operations. Army formations deployed in the state are already stretched thin, engaged in counter-insurgency in the region rather than to patrol the border. The biggest problem is not inadequacy of soldiers but getting them to the border quickly. In Arunachal Pradesh, all roads run along river valleys. Border roads are built all along the valleys, but they are not inter-connected. Lateral access to the state is possible only through Assam. To travel between two

border towns, Nafra and Sarli, just 200 km apart as the crow flies, one has to journey nearly 600 km into Assam.

The poor state of infrastructure has to do with the terrain—China's roads are on the Tibetan plateau, but Indian roads have to negotiate gradients sharply rising from 1,000 ft above sea level to over 20,000 ft. Infrastructure backwardness is also a result of the defensive mindset that crept into the security establishment following the 1962 Indo-China border skirmish. The government did not create roads or

## AIR POWER



India is buying 12 heavy-lift helicopters and 140 air-droppable, ultra-light Howitzers for its new mountain divisions.



The divisions will have integral air support elements like utility helicopters (left), helicopter gunships and UAVs.



**PIB** **RISING: Arunachal CM Dorjee Khandu welcomes Manmohan (left)** strong and developing its military capacity along the border," says former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy.

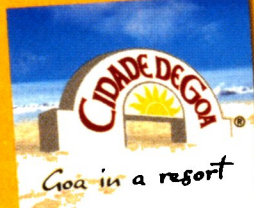
That is obvious from the present ground situation. Of a total of 2,800 km of the disputed Indo-Chinese border in three sectors, over one-third or 1,080

bridges in Arunachal—then North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA)—fearing that such infrastructure could be used by the invading Chinese to roll down into Assam. Instead, a 'reverse scorched earth policy' created a buffer zone along the border with China, but this also meant that the strategically sensitive state remained one of India's most isolated, with abysmal infrastruc-

Kunming—but on the ground, it is laying the groundwork for all eventualities. The package also includes a 45-km railway line linking the state capital Itanagar with Harmuti in Assam and airports at Pasighat, Along, Daporijo, Ziro and Tezu, and a new greenfield airport in Itanagar. "The best way India can counter pressure from China is by being economically


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